

WORSHIP OF THE SELF

Satanism



▲ The face of Satanism

Anton LaVey reveled in his capacity to outrage, adopting an overtly Satanic image and conducting nude rituals. In 1969, he wrote *The Satanic Bible*, the core text of LaVeyan Satanism.

The very word *Satanism* summons images of devil worship and blood sacrifices, but the reality is very different. While modern Satanism, with its atheistic promotion of personal freedom, typically encourages individuals to indulge in what many view as sins (such as greed and lust) and to put themselves first, respect for the rights of others is also a core value.

The Church of Satan

Modern Satanism began in San Francisco on April 30, 1966, which was declared *Anno Satanas*—the first year in the age of Satan.

It was created by American occultist Anton LaVey, and promotes the beliefs that there are no gods or higher beings; that humans have great capacity for self-improvement, but are carnal beings; that there is no afterlife; and that humans are, in effect, gods themselves, able to determine their own destinies by exercising self-will. LaVey named the movement after Satan to shock people, and adopted the sinister goat-headed deity, Baphomet,

as its symbol. Yet Satanists, as atheists, do not believe in the Devil—Satan being a Christian concept, if there is no God, there is no Satan. LaVey's ethos embraces sensual fulfillment, yet his core creeds stress self-discovery and growth as the prime means of personal improvement.

Rites and rituals

Satanic magic typically consists of psychological processes rather than a belief in supernatural forces. There are two primary forms:

“greater” magic involves ritual practices that create the mental space to process emotional or physical events, while “lesser” magic involves the manipulation of a situation in order to achieve a desired outcome by using one's physical attributes or psychological guile.

Satanic rituals are important, but there are no rules: any form of observance may be used, the goal being to allow the will to impose itself. Some Satanists use symbolic objects such as bells, chalices, swords, and elixirs, and may even use a (consenting) nude female as an altar. Crucial to Satanism is the idea that the “self” is the key source of power in any magic or ritual.

Variants and rivals

In 1975, the first group to split away from LaVey's Satanism emerged as the Temple of Set, declaring

belief in Set, the ancient Egyptian god of fire and chaos. Many other Satanic subsects exist, including the Satanic Temple, which broke away in 2013. Calling itself an evolved and updated form of Satanism, it promotes a highly political (left-leaning) agenda.

◀ Satanic altar

An altar is a key component of Satanic rituals, according to LaVey's *Satanic Bible*. A variety of objects may be used, and the symbol of Baphomet is usually present.



▲ The Sigil of Baphomet

The official symbol of the Church of Satan shows the head of Baphomet within an inverted pentagram, enclosed in a circle. It is surrounded by Hebrew characters which, read counterclockwise from the bottom, spell “Leviathan.”

